

By JAVED AKHTAR

"Every shot for him is his first shot"

I was one of the very few in the industry who could see and appreciate the immense talent in this young actor, even as his films were not doing well. There was *Raaste ka Patthar* (1972), a flop—I think besides its producer, I must have been the only one to have seen it thrice. But I could see that Amitabh Bachchan had done a great job. His performances were commendable even in films like *Parwana* (1971) and Mehmood's *Garam Masala* (1972), in which he had a guest appearance playing a comical character called Robert Taylor. I felt that the only thing going against him was a bad script and bad direction.

It took some time to convince Prakash Mehra to cast Bachchan in *Zanjeer* (1973) because he was looking for a 'viable' actor. During the film's production, I remember Mr Mehra saying: 'Javed, thank you for recommending him because I can't imagine making a film without this actor.' I have great respect for Mr Mehra's conviction in the script, because by then every 'viable' actor had refused to play the role, but he didn't

***Deewaar*, *Sholay*, *Trishul*, *Don*, *Muqaddar Ka Sikandar* and *Kaala Patthar* changed not just Amitabh's fate but the very heart and culture of Hindi cinema**

THE MARATHON MAN

For, there was no escaping Bachchan in 2022—as he was going on 80. In April release *Runway 34*, he was playing a no-nonsense head of the Aircraft Accident Investigation Bureau, grilling and lecturing a pompous pilot (Ajay Devgn, a next-generation hero who's himself no spring chicken now). In September, Bachchan was a wise, sword-wielding mentor in *Brahmastra*. The film, having earned Rs 247 crore nationwide, is still running in cinema halls. But he has another one slated for the marquee—*Goodbye*. His co-star is Rashmika Mandanna of *Pushpa* fame, who is just a year senior to Bachchan's granddaughter, Navya Naveli Nanda. Audiences will see him on the big screen in November too, in Sooraj Barjatya's *Uunchai*, alongside Anupam Kher and Boman Irani. And he's still on the small screen, clocking in 14 hours a day to shoot *KBC*, which is in its 14th season. With this kind of a chock-a-block calendar, one would think this is the 1970s-80s, with Bachchan working at such a pace he hardly had time for family.

It was in 1980, when he was at the summit and at his prolific best, that INDIA TODAY featured him on the cover and christened him 'The One-Man Industry'. Perhaps too happening to be considered an 'institution' yet, like older thespians like Dilip Kumar would have been then. But with a good ensemble of films that showcased an eclectic actorly repertoire, comparisons may have started getting made. Two years later, the two came face to face in *Shakti*. But four decades later, Bachchan's career has outlasted other thespian luminaries not just by the sheer volume of films he has done—over 180 and counting, excluding the innumerable ones as narrator—but also with the range of his work. Now, though he's *still* happening, no one would hesitate to confer on him nobler encomiums—like 'the legend', or 'an institution'. His iconic status, as well as his ease before the camera, is precisely what makes him one of the most-trusted names among brands who seek his face and, more significantly, that deep baritone to sell their products and services. The Duff & Phelps Celebrity Brand Valuation Study of 2021 ranked Bachchan sixth, with a brand value of $54.2 million. Even governments have counted on him for their public service advertising campaigns like 'Beti Bachao, Beti Padhao' or to urge citizens to be cautious during the Covid-19 pandemic.

Age usually slows a person, but in Bachchan's case, his zeal to perform and engage with his fans—whether via his films or many social media accounts, including the blog Bol Bachchan—is untouched by senescence. As soon as the second lockdown ended, eager to face the camera again, he called his go-to photographer Avinash Gowariker over.

"Our country has seen many superstars, but stardom with his kind of longevity is a rarity and I think it will be very difficult to match up to it," says *Dangal* maker Nitesh Tiwary, who directed Bachchan in *Bhootnath Returns* and also worked with him in the *KBC* ad campaigns. Like many directors of today, Tiwary